I have remarked on the sagacity of the Supreme Court of India on other occasions, especially when the Lords Justices have passed innovative verdicts that suggest that illegal squatters on urban land should think more carefully about inclement weather, but I am once again amazed at the wisdom and sophistication that some Lord Justices of the Supreme Court, and other distinguished legal professionals like Soli Sorabjee, our erstwhile Attorney General, have displayed in suggesting that even the banal human quality of compassion, or the ordinary, commonplace tendency to doubt that justice has been done when an accused person has gone unheard, or apprehensions about the unleashing of a new spiral of violence, can on occasion be wild, unreasonable, excessive and ever so intemperate. It is evident from the tenor of their pronouncements that cheap sentiments like sympathy, or ordinary doubts about the due processes of trial, or worries about more loss of life, when seen through the exalted filter of national security, are but irritating excesses that need to be held in check. It is as if truth alone must not triumph over what the Supreme Court, the Ministry of Home Affairs and the Intelligence Bureau deem acceptable for the health of the republic.

In view of this, we might as well propose an amendment to the Constitution such that the national motto be expanded to read ‘Sravoccha Nyayalaya-cha-Guptachara Vibhaga-cha-Griha Mantralayasya Satyameva Jayate’. Such a move would yield a national motto that would render a resonant and precise statement about the present status of the concept known as ‘Truth’ in the Indian republic, especially in the wake of the events of 13 December 2001. To have all manner of truths, especially crassly inconvenient and common ones —such as the fact that the Indian State is a brutal colonial power that holds Kashmir and parts of the North-East with the aid of ‘shoot at whim’ laws such as the Armed Forces Special Powers Act—emerge triumphant will simply not do. We need refined and processed truths—such as those that condemn Mohammad Afzal Guru to hang.

Still, it is possible that A.P.J. Abdul Kalam (the man, not necessarily the President, or the erstwhile weapons designer) may have some residual human qualities that may make him look askance at the fact that Mohammad Afzal Guru is sentenced to be hanged in a few days on the basis of statements that actually clearly implicate agencies of the Indian government such as the Special Task Force (STF) that operate in the territory of Jammu and Kashmir in the affair of the attack on the Indian parliament. That is why the Supreme Court must rush to protect A.P.J. Abdul Kalam the President from being